

INTRODUCTION

- Singlehood research has focused on constructs such as commitment to singlehood and voluntary/involuntary singlehood.
- However, these constructs may not fully capture how people understand singlehood in everyday life.
- People may instead understand singlehood in terms of whether they want to stay single or have to stay single.

Research Questions

- Do wanting to stay single and having to stay single differ across qualitative themes about the meaning of singlehood?
- How are wanting to stay single and having to stay single related to existing singlehood constructs?

METHOD

- $N = 820$ single participants
- 463 Men, 348 Women, 9 Other
- $M_{\text{Age}} = 29.10$ years (range: 18-77)
- Majority were white & heterosexual
- Collected from Prolific in Fall 2024 and SONA from Spring 2025 to Spring 2026



Measures

- Two face-valid items to assess wanting and having to stay single rated on a 7-point scale from 1 (strongly disagree) to 7 (strongly agree).
 - I want to stay single.*
 - I have to stay single.*
- After answering questions about singlehood/single lifestyle, participants described what singlehood meant to them or what they were referring to in their own words.

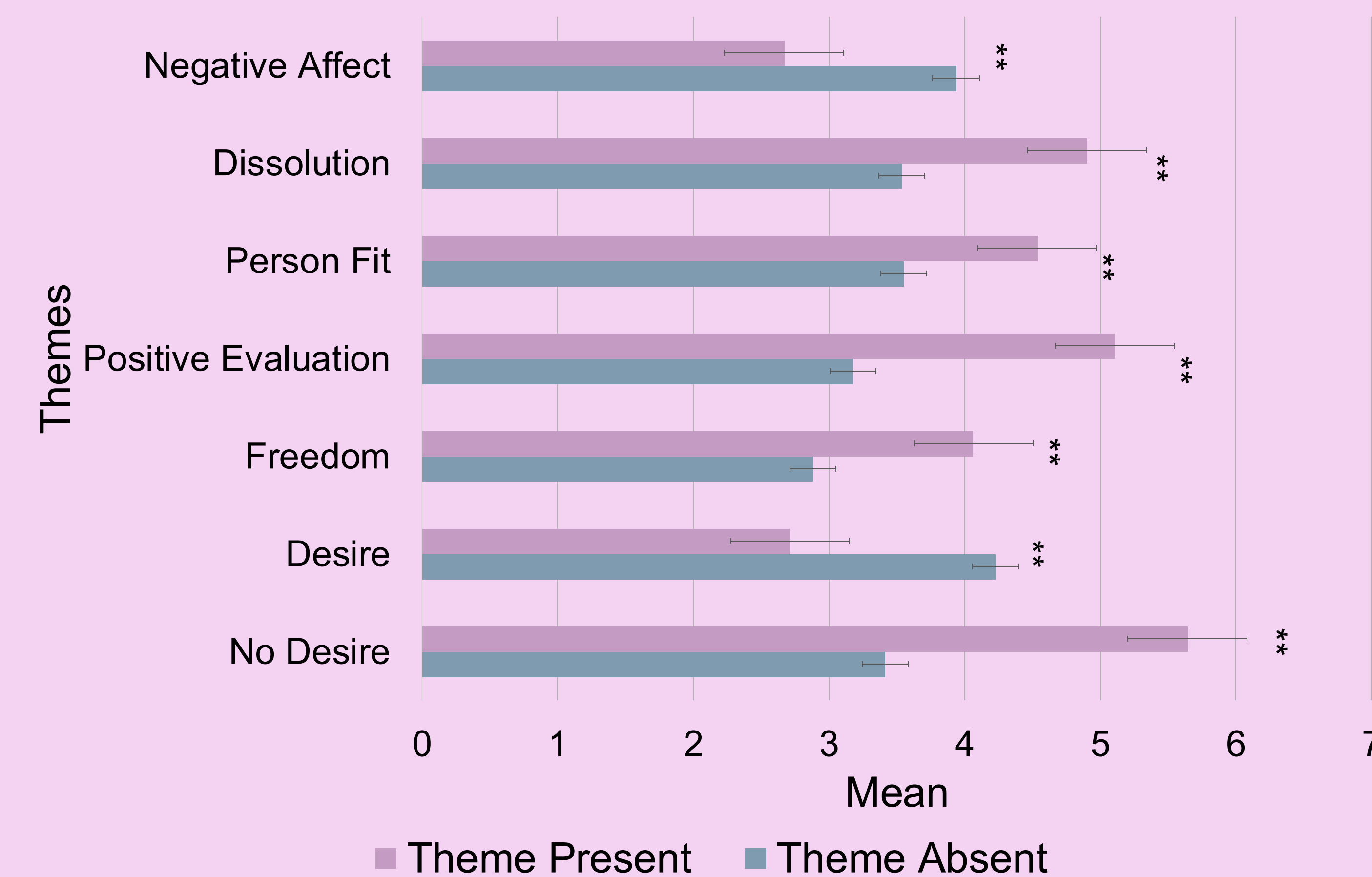
ANALYSIS PLAN

- Theme variables were coded using agreement-only cases
- Each qualitative theme was treated as a binary outcome (0 = not present, 1 = present).
- We estimated separate t-test models for each theme predicting want and have.

RESULTS

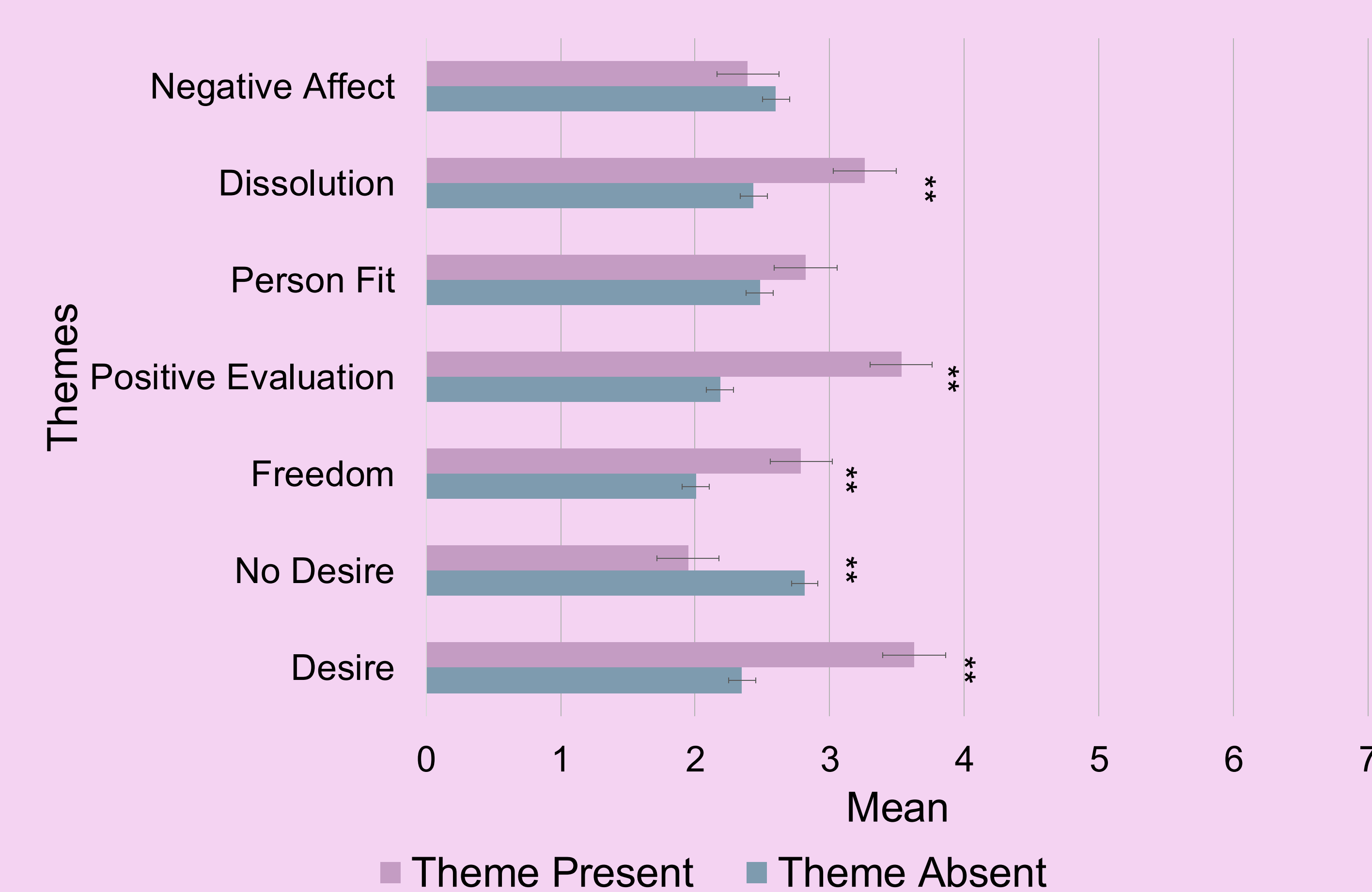
- Benefits themes and dissolution were linked to higher wanting and having to stay single.
- Person fit, no desire, and absence of negative affect were linked to wanting to stay single, while the presence of desire was linked to having to stay single.
- Wanting to stay single was strongly related to commitment and moderately related to voluntary singlehood.
- Having to stay single was moderately related to commitment and weakly related to voluntary singlehood.

Figure 1. Wanting to Stay Single by Theme Endorsement



Note. ** indicates $p < .05$

Figure 2. Having to Stay Single by Theme Endorsement



Note. ** indicates $p < .05$

Table 1. Means, Standard Deviations, and correlations among wanting and having to stay single

Variable	M	SD	1	2	3
1. Commitment	3.72	1.66			
2. Want	3.75	1.82	0.81		
3. Have	2.56	1.73	0.59	0.55	
4. Voluntary Singlehood	4.76	1.59	0.45	0.47	0.20

Note. M and SD are used to represent mean and standard deviation. Bolded indicates $p < .01$.

MEANING OF SINGLEHOOD THEMES

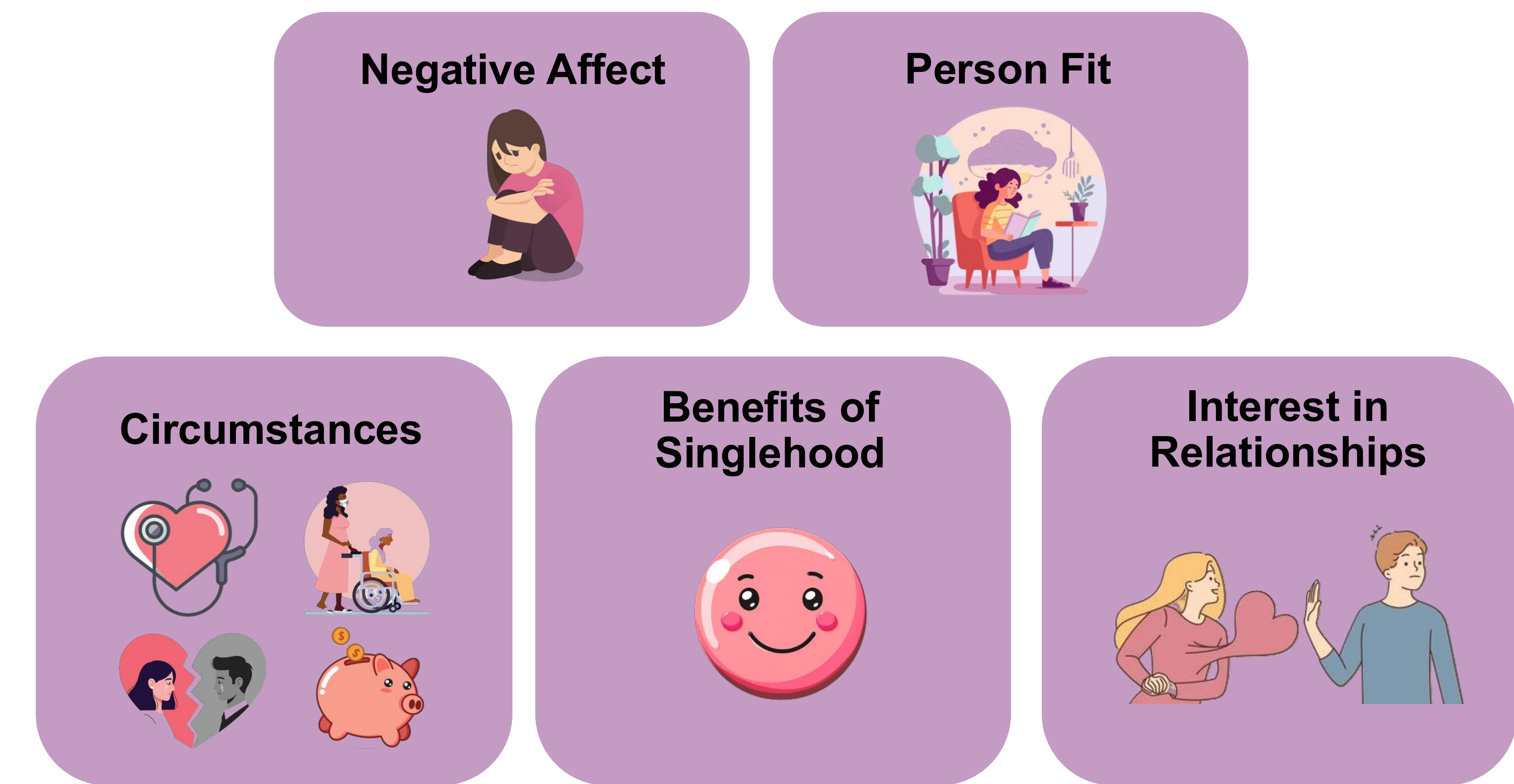
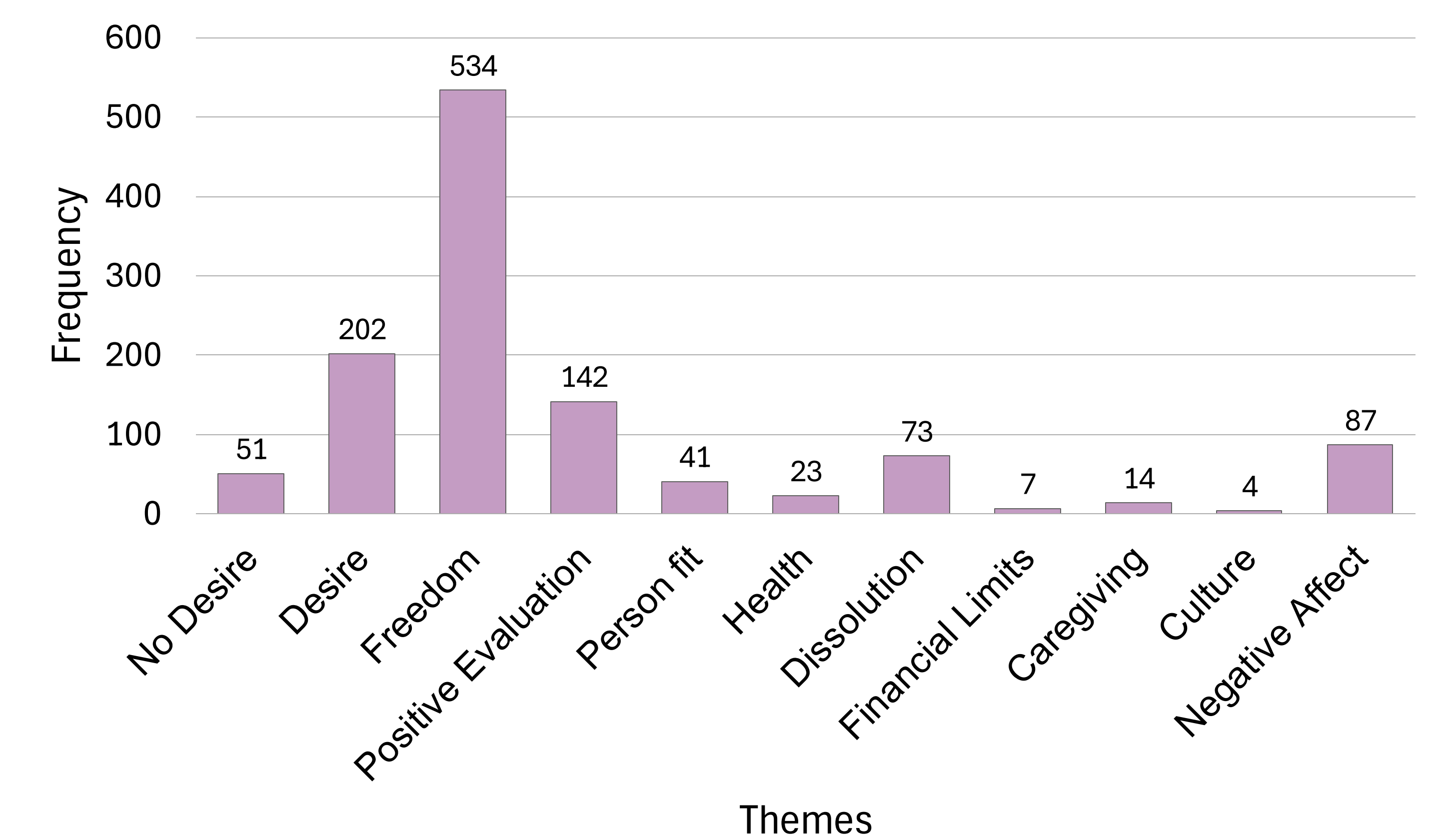


Figure 3. Frequency of Meaning of Singlehood Themes



DISCUSSION

- People who want to or feel they have to stay single experience a sense of choice and satisfaction with their singlehood.
- Those who want to stay single tend to express no desire for a relationship, whereas those who have to stay single tend to express a desire for a relationship.
- Wanting to stay single and having to stay single may be a combination of commitment to singlehood and voluntary singlehood.